Example Interaction Diagram

Brew & Go Coffee Shop Ordering App

Persona: Maya, a busy grad student ordering her usual drink before class

How to read this diagram:

User Action	What Maya does — tap, select, confirm	**System Response**	What the app does back — displays, pre-fills, confirms
Decision Point (◇)	A fork — two or more paths branch from here	**Friction / Breakdown**	Where the original app failed — the reason for the redesign

Slide 2 → Full diagram Slide 3 → What to notice

Interaction Diagram · Brew & Go Coffee Shop App · Persona: Maya (Busy Grad Student)

MAYA (USER)	APP (SYSTEM)	NOTES
Opens the app *On her way to class*	**Loads home screen** *Displays saved 'usual' + full menu*	*System recognizes Maya — personalization begins*
⚠️ **ORIGINAL APP: No saved preferences — Maya had to rebuild her order from scratch every time**	**★ REDESIGN: Pre-fills 'Maya's Usual'** *Saves her from navigating full menu each visit*	*Design change: memory + recognition over recall. This is the core redesign.*
Taps 'Maya's Usual' card *One tap — no menu browsing*	**Opens order review screen** *Pre-fills: Oat milk · Large · 2 pumps vanilla · Hot*	*System does the work — user just confirms*
Wants changes? *YES: Edit order* *NO: Confirm*	**Awaits user action** *Edit options visible if needed*	*◇ Decision point — two paths branch here*
Taps 'Place Order' *Confirms without changes (most common path)*	**Processes order → Confirms** *Shows: Order #427 · Ready in 4 min · Progress bar*	*Positive signal: green banner + wait time = emotional reassurance*

What to Notice in This Diagram · Apply these observations to your own

1 Every user action has a system response

Maya taps the 'usual' card — system opens the order review screen. She taps Place Order — system confirms with an order number and wait time. Both sides of the conversation are always shown.

2 The friction point is labeled and explained

The dashed red box shows exactly where the original app failed: no saved preferences, so Maya had to rebuild her order every time. Label your breakdown point. It is the justification for your whole redesign.

3 The decision point shows both paths

The diamond at 'Wants changes?' branches into Yes (edit) and No (confirm). Even the less common path is acknowledged. A decision point needs at least two visible outcomes to be a decision.

4 System responses explain the design intention

The system box doesn't just say 'shows confirmation' — it says 'green banner + wait time = emotional reassurance.' Connect your system responses to the design principle they serve.

5 Notes column connects rows to the design problem

Each notes cell links the interaction to the redesign rationale: 'Design change: memory over recall.' Your notes column should do the same — not just describe, but explain why it matters.

6 Diagram and prototype show the same interaction

The prototype simulates Maya ordering her usual. The diagram maps the same interaction as logic. They are two views of one thing. Your diagram and prototype should always be in sync.